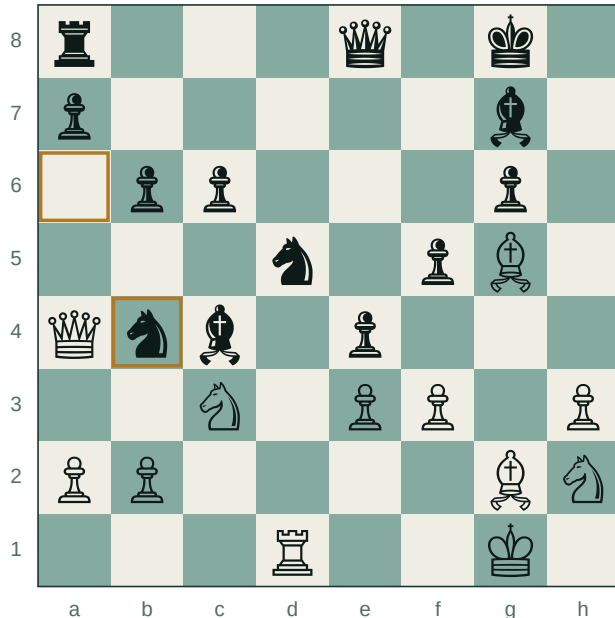


Capture the defender: White, move 25

Capture the defender

White to move



Previous move: 24...Nab4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

25. Nxd5 cxd5 26. Qxb4

25.Nxd5 The knight captures the knight on d5. Recorded reply: **25...cxd5**.

26.Qxb4 The queen captures the knight on b4.

At the end, nominal material is White 28 / Black 26 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +3: the balance goes from -1 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on g8. Geometrically undefended: bishop on c4. Check for tactical protection.